

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN GREECE

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide uses the Greek terms and bodies you'll actually run into — the environmental terms (AEPO), the EIA, the Council of State (Symvoulío tis Epikrateias), the aítisi akýroseos — and explains each in plain words the first time. Greece is an EU member state, and that is the single most powerful fact in this guide.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

For over half a century, successive Greek governments wanted to divert the **Acheloo River** — the largest river in Greece — across the Pindos mountains to irrigate the Thessaly plain, building giant dams and moving water on a colossal scale, at vast ecological and human cost. And for twenty-three years, a patient coalition of communities, environmental organisations (ELLINIKI ETAIRIA, WWF Hellas, the ornithological and nature societies), and their lawyers fought it in court — and won. Greece's supreme administrative court, the **Council of State (Symvoulío tis Epikrateias)**, ruled against the diversion again and again from 1994 onward; in 2009 it referred the case to the **Court of Justice of the European Union**, which found the project breached EU water, habitats, and environmental-assessment law and rested on inadequate, outdated data; and finally the **Plenary of the Council of State** struck the whole scheme down. A project three generations of politicians treated as a national priority was defeated — because a community, its lawyers, and EU law together are, in Greece, genuinely hard to beat.

The coalition that beat the Acheloo diversion — communities, ELLINIKI ETAIRIA, WWF Hellas, the nature societies, and their lawyers — drew on the decisive feature most of the world's communities lack: **Greece is a member state of the European Union**. Its government is bound by **EU environmental law** it cannot lawfully override; its independent supreme court, the **Council of State**, applies that law and can refer a case to the **Court of Justice of the European Union**, as it did over Acheloo; and it answers to the **European Commission**. That combination — EU law, a real court, and Brussels — is the most powerful tool in this guide. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states the second truth plainly, because Greece teaches both. The **Skouries** gold and copper mine in Halkidiki drew one of Europe's most committed community movements — years of protest, occupation, and litigation from 2012 — and yet the mine was re-approved, financed, and built: the economic crisis wore the movement down, the state stayed aligned with the investor, and the resistance was met with heavy policing and prosecutions. Greece shows both what the levers can win and where a determined, state-backed project can grind through even a fierce resistance — which situation you face shapes everything.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A major Greek project needs its **approval of environmental terms (AEPO)**, resting on an environmental impact assessment; where it touches a **Natura 2000** site, protected water, or a forest it runs into hard EU law; it can be challenged in the **Council of State**; and it needs public acceptance. Every one of those is a link you can grab. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull** — and in Greece, the EU-law link is often the strongest.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the project hits EU-protected water, habitats, or species, or the assessment is flawed, the Council of State and EU law genuinely bite** — that's the Acheloos lever, and it defeated a fifty-year national priority.
- **If the state and the investor are determined and the process was clean, it's a hard grind** — Skouries shows a fierce resistance can still be worn down, so plan for endurance and count delay and conditions as wins.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **use the rights the law gives you** — the consultation, EU law, the Council of State, the European Commission — and **run every front at once**: the documents, the consultation, the courts, Brussels, the movement, the press. That's how Acheloos was won.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The core decision is the **AEPO** — the approval of environmental terms (*Apofasi Egkrisis Perivallontikon Oron*) — issued by the environment ministry or the region, resting on an environmental impact assessment. The **region** and **municipality** hold planning and land-use powers. And above all of them sits **EU law**, binding every level, enforced by the **Council of State** and, ultimately, the **European Commission** and the **Court of Justice of the EU**. Know which decision you can contest — and remember the EU-law argument runs through all of them.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The assessment and public consultation. The developer files the environmental impact assessment; it goes to **public consultation**. *Your opening* — and it arms every later step: file substantive objections now, especially on EU-law grounds (Natura 2000, water, species). They become the record the court reviews.

The AEPO. The authority approves the environmental terms. *Your opening* — a hard clock: challenge it in the Council of State, usually **within 60 days**.

Construction and operation. *Your opening*: breaches of the environmental terms, and complaints to the European Commission.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — company records set the exposure. **What it still needs** — the AEPO not final or under challenge, the financing not closed: whatever's missing is the soft spot. **Who's paying** — banks, and often **EU funds**, which carry environmental conditions and can be jeopardised by an EU-law breach.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment ministry and the region** run the AEPO and can be pressed. The **Council of State** reviews the legality of the approval and can suspend and annul it — the Acheloos route. The **European Commission** enforces EU environmental law against Greece, and the **Court of Justice** can rule the state in breach. The **Ombudsman (Synigoros tou Politi)** takes maladministration

complaints. And Greece's **committed environmental movement, its organisations, and a free press** are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition that carried Acheloos through 23 years.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether EU-protected water, habitats, or species are engaged, whether the assessment is flawed, and how determined the state and the investor are.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections in the consultation	15–35%	during assessment	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Council of State challenge	30–55%	1–4 yr	mod	AEPO suspended or annulled
EU-law grounds (Natura 2000, water, EIA)	35–60%	1–5 yr	mod	Approval struck down (Acheloos)
Complaint to the European Commission → CJEU	30–55%	1–5 yr	low	Greece found in breach; project stopped
Movement + media	25–50%	months–yr	low	Political cost; project reconsidered
Everything together (EU trigger, public watching)	40–65%	1–5 yr	mod	Struck down, delayed, changed
Everything together (state/investor-backed, clean process)	20–40%	1–5 yr	mod	Delayed, conditioned, exposed (or, like Skouries, built)

The levers that move the needle most are the **Council of State armed with EU law** and a **complaint to the European Commission**, backed by the movement and the press. Acheloos shows the ceiling (a fifty-year national priority struck down). The honest floor is Skouries — a fierce resistance ground down by a determined, state-backed investor. Most fights sit between, and honest wins include a struck-down or conditioned AEPO, delay, and exposure as much as a clean stop.

On cost: objecting and organising are cheap, and a complaint to the European Commission is free and can be filed by anyone; environmental organisations and residents' groups have standing before the Council of State. The EU-law route is what levels the field.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this AEPO, this flaw, this EU-protected line — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the company, its owners, its financiers (especially any EU funds).

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Get the boundaries and lay them over what EU and Greek law protect — a **Natura 2000** site, protected species, a water body under the Water Framework Directive, a forest, a coast. **A Natura 2000 site or protected water is your sharpest lever**, so this map is your most important document — Acheloos turned on EU water and habitats law.

3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is the consultation open? Has the AEPO issued (starting the 60-day clock to the Council of State)? These openings are strictly time-bound.

4. What does it still need that it lacks? An AEPO not final, permits not granted, financing not closed. The missing piece is the soft spot.

5. Who else is affected, and who already opposes it? Neighbours, local groups, national organisations (WWF Hellas, the nature and ornithological societies). Acheloos united communities with national organisations for over two decades.

What this looks like in real life. A community learns a project is planned that will damage a Natura 2000 wetland and a protected river, and the assessment waves the EU-law problem away. The five questions yield: a named company (and EU funds); a site on EU-protected water and habitat (the sharp lever); a consultation open now with an AEPO pending; a project still needing that approval; and a coalition of neighbours and national organisations. That's the Acheloos pattern — object on EU-law grounds now, and get the Council of State and Brussels ready.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the decision rests on — the environmental impact assessment, the AEPO and its conditions, the Natura 2000 assessment, the water and species studies. Greece's environmental-information rights (from the Aarhus Convention and EU law) let you demand what isn't public. Then read the assessment hard for flaws — an understated impact, an ignored alternative, a Natura 2000 site brushed over, outdated data (the Acheloos flaw), a water-body impact minimised.

Layer two: the ground truth. Dated, located photographs and video of the site, the river, the wetland, the wildlife — baseline images before any damage most of all — and the testimony of affected neighbours.

Layer three: the map of EU protections. Lay the project over every Natura 2000 site, protected species, and protected water body it touches, so each EU-law lever is visible. Walking into the Council of State — or the European Commission — with the assessment, the AEPO, and that map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The assessment, the AEPO and conditions, the Natura 2000 and water studies** — from the ministry or region; force out the rest under the environmental-information rules (8A).
- **Regional and municipal planning documents** — from the region and municipality.
- **Ownership and financing** — company records, and EU-fund documents.
- **The EU-protections map** — Natura 2000 sites, protected species, and protected water bodies, laid over the site.
- **Dated site evidence and named testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, and neighbours' statements.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; people give you power — and Acheloos's coalition held for 23 years. Build yours in four moves.

Start with a tight core. The neighbours most affected, the people who know the land and water, a few tireless organisers, and respected local figures.

Form a committee or citizens' initiative. A named, organised group that speaks with one voice in the consultation, the courts, and the press. Hold meetings where people see the evidence — the map of the project over the Natura 2000 site.

Bring in national organisations — early. WWF Hellas, the Hellenic Ornithological Society, ELLINIKI ETAIRIA, and the nature societies bring legal and scientific firepower, standing before the Council of State, and the endurance to fight for years. Team up early and hand them your documents.

Build to last. Greek fights can run for decades — Acheloos took 23 years. Build clear roles, a secure shared archive, a way to decide together, and a plan for the financial and emotional toll — and, if direct action is contemplated, get legal advice first, and be aware (as Skouries showed) that protest can be met with heavy policing.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES & EU LAW

Law is Greece's sharpest lever, because the Council of State genuinely enforces the law — and because EU law gives grounds the state cannot override.

Object First — It Builds the Record

Everything downstream is stronger if you filed substantive objections in the consultation, especially on EU-law grounds. The Council of State reviews the AEPO on that record, so your objections are the raw material of the challenge.

The Council of State — and the Power of EU Law

If the AEPO is granted, you challenge it in the **Council of State** by an **application for annulment (aitisi akYROseos)**, usually **within 60 days**, and you can also seek a **suspension (anastoli)** to freeze the works while the case runs. The strongest grounds are **European**: the **Habitats and Birds Directives** (Natura 2000 and species), the **Water Framework Directive** (a project worsening a water body's status), and the **EIA Directive** (a defective assessment). These are hard, enforceable rules a Greek court must apply — and the Council of State has struck down major projects on them, referring Acheloos to the CJEU itself.

The European Commission — Brussels as a Second Front

Run a parallel front in Brussels: **complain to the European Commission** that the project breaches EU environmental law. It's free, anyone can do it, and the Commission can open infringement proceedings and take Greece to the **Court of Justice**, which can rule the state in breach and order the project stopped. Because Greek projects often use **EU funds**, the EU-law angle has real bite.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the Council of State and EU law are powerful, but litigation is slow; a determined, state-backed investor can grind through, as Skouries did; the 60-day deadline is strict; and protest can be heavily policed.

So use the strong tools — the objections, the Council of State, EU law, the European Commission — but pair them with the movement and the media, be ready for a long fight, and count a struck-down or conditioned AEPO, delay, and exposure as wins alongside a clean stop.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

A document becomes a legal flaw. Not "the assessment is bad" but *"it ignored the impact on this Natura 2000 site and rested on outdated data — so, as at Acheloos, the approval breaches EU law."*

A water body becomes a barrier. *"This would worsen the status of a protected water body, which the Water Framework Directive forbids."*

A breach becomes a Brussels complaint. *"This violates the Habitats Directive; we've complained to the European Commission."*

The harm becomes a public story. *"The river, the wetland, the water our community has always known — for a project decided over our heads."*

Match it to the venue: the objections to the authority; the EU-law grounds to the Council of State; the breach to the European Commission; the human and the landscape to the press.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Greece, publicity is power — Acheloos and Skouries became national causes. A free press, an engaged public, and a committed movement make the media front central.

Lead with people and place, not procedure. Not "the AEPO was procedurally deficient" but "the river, the wetland, the water our community has always known — for a project decided over our heads." Use your strongest material: dated photographs, the map of the project over the Natura 2000 site, named neighbours, and any court or Commission action banked.

Work several audiences at once — including Europe. Local and national press build political pressure; the environmental movement amplifies; and European media and institutions reach the Commission, which can act on Greece. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And protect people — get legal advice before any direct action, and expect heavy policing of protest.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Environmental-information request (to the ministry / region).

Subject: Request for environmental information — [project].

"Under the environmental-information rules, we, residents of [place], request the environmental impact assessment, the AEPO and its conditions, and the Natura 2000 and water studies for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the consultation.

Subject: Objection — public consultation on [project].

"We, residents of [place], object to the approval of [project]: [it damages this Natura 2000 site / this protected water body; the assessment rests on outdated data and ignores alternatives]. We ask that the environmental terms be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — To a national organisation (WWF Hellas / a nature society).

Subject: Request for support and a Council of State challenge — [project].

"Our community faces [project] on [a Natura 2000 site / protected water]. We've gathered [the assessment, the AEPO, photographs, surveys] and believe it breaches [the Habitats / Water Framework / EIA Directive]. We ask for your legal and scientific support and, if warranted, a challenge, working as partners. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8D — Instructing a lawyer (aitisi akvroseos).

Subject: Application for annulment — AEPO for [project].

"We instruct you to challenge the AEPO for [project], issued on [date], in the Council of State, and to seek a suspension, on the grounds that [it breaches the Habitats / Water Framework / EIA Directive / the assessment was defective]. Please act within the 60-day deadline. [Attach the AEPO, the assessment and our evidence.]"

8E — Complaint to the European Commission.

Subject: Possible breach of EU environmental law — [project], Greece.

"We report a possible breach of EU environmental law (the Habitats/Birds/Water Framework/EIA Directives) by [project] at [location], which damages the [named] Natura 2000 site / worsens a protected water body without proper assessment. [Attach evidence.]"

8F — Letter to the press.

Subject: [Community] moves to protect [river / wetland / forest] from [project].

"For generations the people of [place] have lived beside [the river / the wetland] at [location] — a place protected across Europe. Now [project] threatens to destroy it. We can provide photographs, documents, a map and interviews. [Contact.]"

8G — To an EU-fund body.

Subject: EU-law and funding risk in [project].

"We understand [project] at [location] may be [EU-funded] and that it damages a Natura 2000 site / protected water in possible breach of EU law. We ask you to weigh this against the environmental conditions attached to EU funds. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8H — Rallying the community.

Subject: We can stop this — here's how.

"[Project] threatens [our river / wetland / forest]. At Acheloos, communities and their lawyers beat a fifty-year national project with EU law and the Council of State. With the consultation, the courts, the European Commission, and the movement behind us, we have a real chance. Please join us: object, share what you know, and stand with us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Nail down the project and its footprint, and look for an EU trigger.** A Natura 2000 site or protected water is your sharpest lever.
2. **File substantive objections in the consultation (8B), on EU-law grounds.** They become the court's record.
3. **Request the assessment and AEPO (8A), and read them for flaws and outdated data.**
4. **Photograph everything, with dates and places.** Baseline images before any damage matter most.
5. **Watch the 60-day clock and challenge the AEPO in the Council of State (8D) — and complain to the European Commission (8E).**
6. **Team up with a national organisation and go public (8C/8F).** Greece's movement and EU law have beaten national priorities.

Even lean, those six use your rights, protect the deadline, build the record, and open the EU-law front.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Greece's tools are real, but the field can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When the state and investor are determined. Skouries shows a fierce resistance can be ground down. Don't fold: press the EU-law grounds, use the Council of State and the Commission, keep the movement alive, and make the state's backing of a flawed project a public and European cost.

When a won fight is revived. Acheloos keeps being brought back politically. A win must be defended — watch for revival attempts and be ready to litigate again.

When protest is policed hard. Expect heavy policing and prosecutions of protest. Get legal advice, keep direct action lawful and disciplined, and protect your people.

What still works, and it's a lot. The Council of State genuinely strikes down unlawful approvals; EU law gives hard, enforceable grounds; the European Commission can force a stop; and a committed coalition has beaten a fifty-year national priority.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Greece has had real problems with the closeness of powerful interests to public decisions, so this matters.

How to spot it. Approvals against the assessment's own findings; a process rushed to suit an investor; revolving doors; public contracts or EU funds steered to the connected; benefits to a few while the community carries the harm.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **Ombudsman (Synigoros tou Politi)** takes maladministration complaints. The **anti-corruption authority and prosecutors** handle graft. The **Court of Audit** examines public money. The **Council of State** can annul a tainted approval, and the **European Commission** can act where EU funds are misused. And Greece's **investigative press** has exposed captured projects.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the process was bent, who benefits, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the Ombudsman, the prosecutors, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the legal challenge and the public campaign.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documents build your proof; pinning down the EU trigger aims it; organising builds the muscle; the Council of State and the Commission press the case; the media raises the cost. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall.

Early on (weeks 1–8): nail down the project, its footprint, and any Natura 2000 or protected water; object in the consultation on EU-law grounds; request the records; photograph the baseline; team up with a national organisation and a lawyer; build your core.

In the thick of it (months–years): challenge the AEPO in the Council of State within 60 days, seek a suspension, and complain to the European Commission; deepen the coalition and the expert critique; open the media front at home and in Europe.

The long haul (years): carry the case through the Council of State and, via the Commission, the CJEU; keep the movement and the pressure alive; hold the line for a struck-down or conditioned AEPO, delay, or an outright stop — and defend any win against revival.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Greece can be done — communities and their lawyers beat a fifty-year plan to divert the country's largest river, with EU law and the Council of State — and the same country is honest about the limit: at Skouries, a fierce resistance was ground down by a determined, state-backed investor. Hold both. Greece's tools are real and, in one respect, unusually strong: membership of the EU, whose environmental law the state cannot override; an independent supreme court that applies it; and a European Commission and Court of Justice that can force a stop. And the constraints are real: slow litigation, determined state-backed projects, strict deadlines, and heavily policed protest.

Here's the discipline that wins. Find the EU trigger — the Natura 2000 site, the protected water — and the flaw in the assessment, and pry loose the record. Object on EU-law grounds in the consultation. Challenge the AEPO in the Council of State within 60 days, seek a suspension, and open a second front by complaining to the European Commission. Team up with a national organisation, carry the story to the public and to Europe, and be ready to defend a win against revival. Count a struck-down or conditioned AEPO, delay, and exposure as wins alongside a clean stop. That's what Acheloos did — the community, the Council of State, and EU law together, across 23 years. So can you.